

TSA Complaints

Airport complaints have risen dramatically since COVID (2020). We were able to visualize this increase using public data on filed airport complaints provided by the U.S. Department of transportation. Have a complaint of your own? Anyone can file a complaint using their website here: <https://www.transportation.gov/airconsumer/file-consumer-complaint>. But the question remains, why has there been such an increase? Is it across all airports? What is the impact? How can we change this?

Before we dig into the data, we want to highlight our focus area, Orlando International Airport (MCO). MCO was chosen due to the high number of complaints and vicinity to our current location. MCO faces significant customer dissatisfaction, particularly with Expedited Passenger Screening Programs. Florida as a whole, ranks among one of the top states for airport complaints, with MCO leading in nearly every category despite similar passenger volumes to other airports such as Miami International Airport (MIA) (57.74M vs. 52.34M in 2023).

Our chosen **audience** are MCO Board Members. Due to their decision-making power and familiarity with the airport and its operations. We crafted the story in such a way that when presented, the audience gains a full understanding of how and why we came to our final conclusion/suggestion. Given Board Members focus on customer experience and profitability, we made sure to include notes regarding the potential for increased profitability after reducing customer complaints. Overall, MCO Board Members have the most vested interest in decreasing complaints and have the authority to implement changes. As the message we are trying to get across in our medium, is not an easy one to implement.. and MCO would be the first airport in the country to do it.

The **purpose** of our message to the MCO Board Members is to convince the board to de-commission CLEAR. Based on our analysis, this will be the best way to reduce the complaints around Expedited Passenger Screening Programs. CLEAR, TSA PreCheck, and other programs fall under this category. However, we believe that by removing the CLEAR program from MCO, we can increase customer satisfaction of our other Expedited Programs. Why? CLEAR is a third-party program intended to expedite ID verification. However, once in put into practice, it results in longer lines and increased frustration. Community feedback on platforms like Reddit confirms CLEAR's negative impact, with complaints about understaffed CLEAR lanes and minimal time savings (approximately 2 minutes). Comparatively, airports like Dallas Love Field (DAL), which never implemented CLEAR, report lower expedited screening complaints despite similar passenger loads. This

suggests CLEAR exacerbates MCO's complaints regarding Expedited Passenger Screening Programs. We can also see the sharp increase in complaints just months after CLEAR went live at MCO. Removing CLEAR has the potential to reduce complaints, staff frustration (improving morale), staff turnover, and ultimately increases profitability (meaning aspect to our chosen audience).

We chose a PowerPoint presentation as our **medium**. It was chosen for its ability to deliver text and oral details as well as visual evidence in a boardroom setting. PowerPoints are also easy to distribute via email for later reviews or follow-up discussions. We included 6 visuals with increasing depth/detail to show board members exactly how we came to our conclusion. The design also uses Gestalt principles, with aligned text and visuals for clarity, consistent spacing for readability, and contrasting colors (e.g., red for high complaints, green for low) to highlight trends. The MCO logo was added to further highlight our audience and create a theme around the airport's colors.

Ethical considerations are critical, as missteps could damage trust between us and our audience. The data, sourced from DOT complaint datasets, IATA/ICAO codes, and DOT passenger count data was verified for accuracy. However, we know we are missing complaints that were made verbally to staff and never submitted online. I personally have found myself frustrated at an airport but never filed an official complaint. There could be entire categories of complaints that we are missing. Even given this possibility, we are still confident that our message holds. Given the sheer number of Expedited Passenger Screening Program complaints at MCO after CLEAR's launch. We did make some modifications to our data (filtering out categories with fewer than 10 complaints) but this is made clear within our presentation. While CLEAR is highlighted, I avoided shaming the program, focusing instead on its impact and offering decommissioning as a solution. No legal or regulatory barriers were identified, but I noted California's ongoing discussions to ban third-party checks, reinforcing the proposal's relevance. To mitigate risks, I recommend ongoing monitoring of complaint trends post-de-commissioning to validate the solution's effectiveness.

Medium can be found on the page after sources

Unique Data Source Submitted Separately

<https://www.transtats.bts.gov/DataElements.aspx?Data=1>

Sources

Busiest airports in Florida - Tampa Bay Business Journal. (2024, July 5). Tampa Bay Business Journal. <https://www.bizjournals.com/tampabay/subscriber-only/2024/07/05/busiest-airports-in-florida.html>

U.S. DEPARTMENT OF TRANSPORTATION. Bureau of Transportation Statistics. (n.d.). https://www.transtats.bts.gov/Data_Elements.aspx?Data=1

Administration, T. S. (2024, April 30). CLEAR becomes TSA's third official TSA PreCheck® enrollment provider. Prnewswire. https://www.prnewswire.com/news-releases/clear-becomes-tsas-third-official-tsa-precheck-enrollment-provider-302131510.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com



IMPROVING MCO CUSTOMER SATISFACTION

Focus: ***Expedited Passenger Screening Program***

Orlando International Airport (MCO)
Customer Service Team

January 2nd, 2025

AGENDA

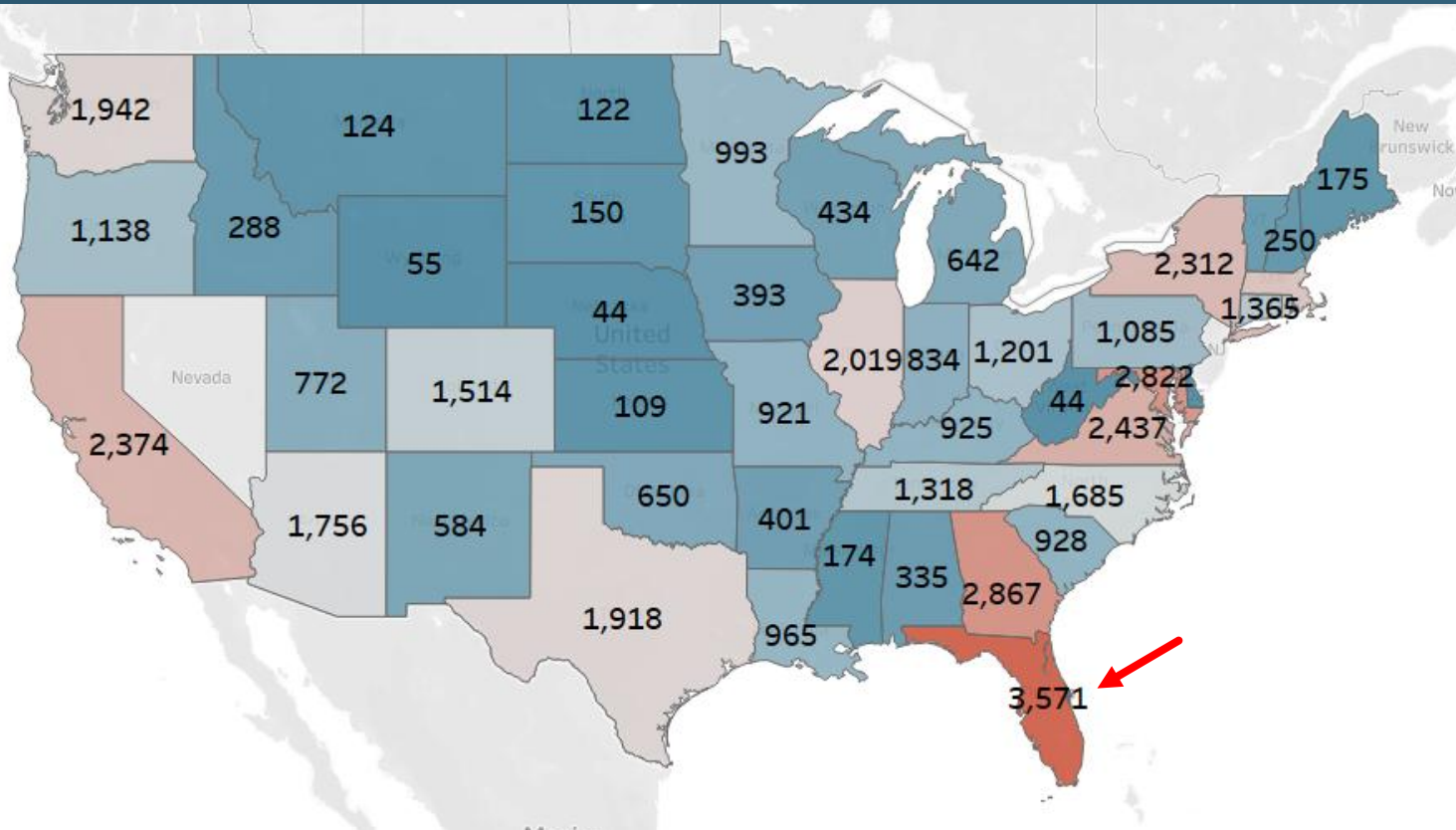
1. Customer Complaints by State
2. How MCO Stands Out
3. MCO Complaints Over Time
4. *Expedited Passenger Screening Program Complaints*
5. *The Impact of CLEAR...*
6. *Proposed Solution*
7. *Why?*

Customer Complaints by State (2015 through 2023)



Florida ranks as one of the top States for Airport Customer dissatisfaction. Falling just behind New Jersey and Nevada*. There was an average of 3,571 filed complaints per Florida airport from 2015 through 2023.

Avg. Complaints by State and # of Airports (2015 through 2023)



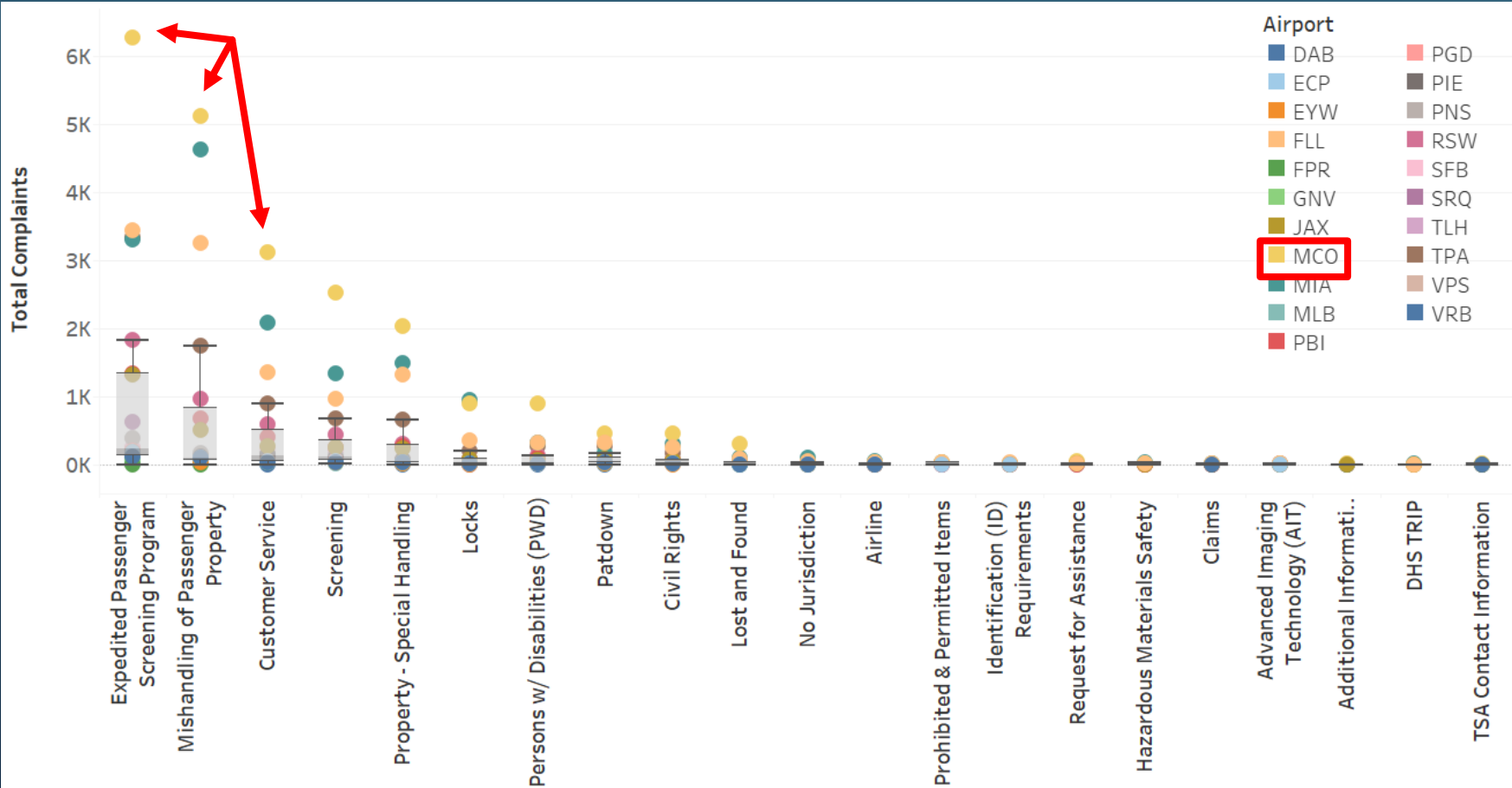
*New Jersey and Nevada were excluded from view as they are outliers in the data due to the sheer number of visitors.

How MCO Stands Out



MCO has the most reported complaints in almost every category. While this can be somewhat attributed to the number of passengers (57.74M in 2023 ¹), MIA has a similar count (52.34M in 2023 ¹) with far fewer complaints.

Complaints by Category & FL Airports (2015 through 2023)



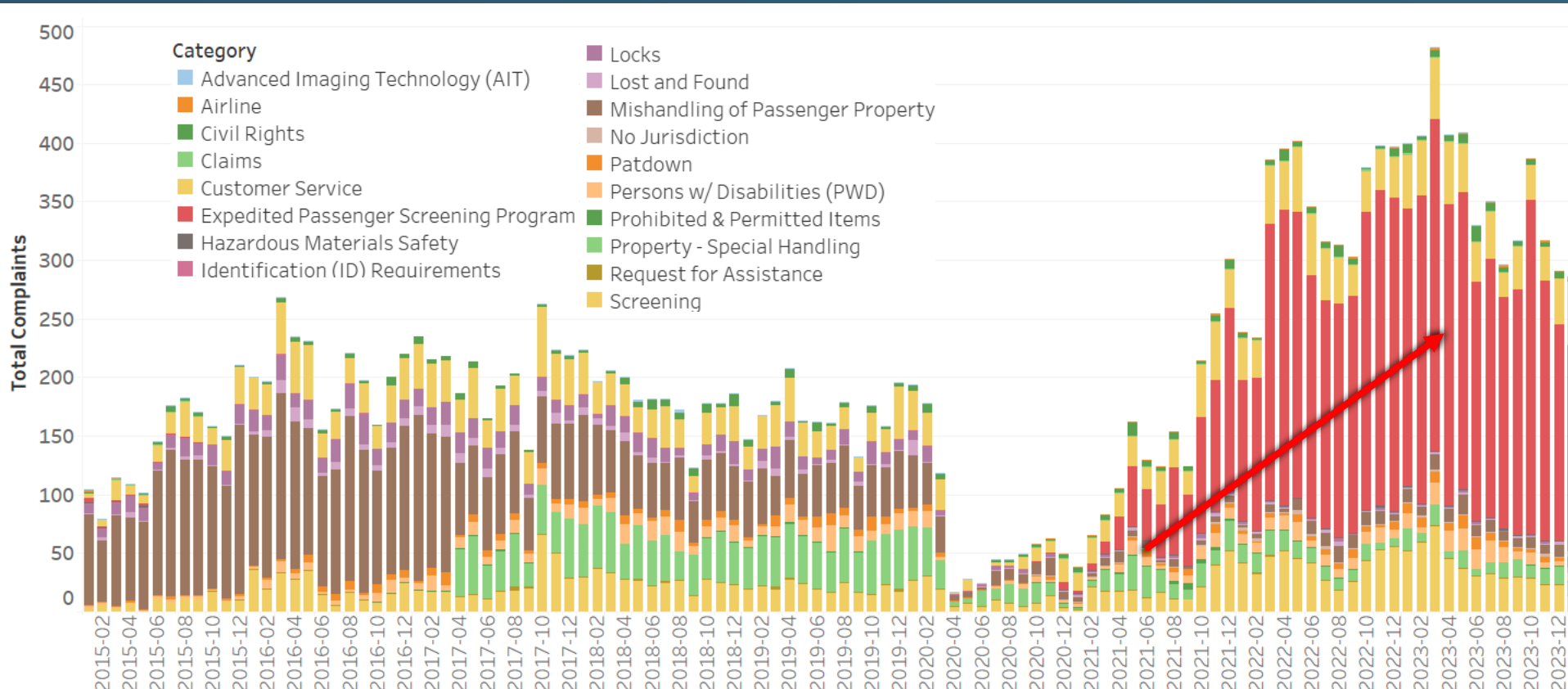
¹(Busiest Airports in Florida - Tampa Bay Business Journal, 2024)
*Excluded categories with 10 or less total complaints.

MCO Complaints Over Time



The number of complaints has skyrocketed in recent years in almost every category. We can clearly see the impact of the changes made to *Hazardous Material Safety* requirements, however the steep increase in complaints around the *Expedited Passenger Screening Program* is a concern. As decreased customer satisfaction leads to more stress on workers, low employee moral, high turn over, and decreased profitability.

Total MCO Complaints by Category



Note: The *Expedited Passenger Screening Program* was rolled out at MCO in **2013**. Not 2021 as this chart may suggest. However, we did introduce on-site TSA PreCheck enrollment in August of 2022.

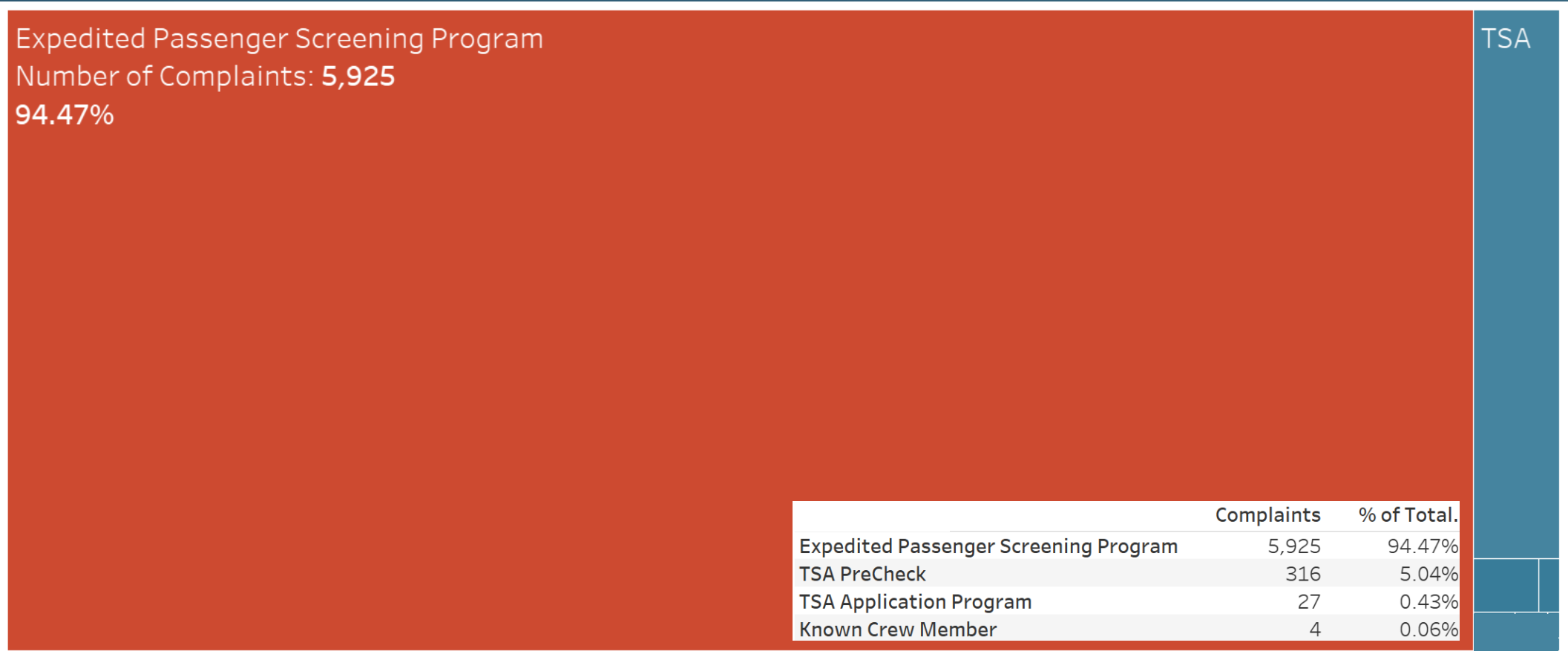
*Excluded categories with 10 or less total complaints.

Expedited Passenger Screening Program Complaints



Multiple programs fall under the Expedited Passenger Screening Program with the goal of a faster screening process. Such as TSA/DoD PreCheck, Global Entry, CLEAR, and Random Selection. Almost 95% of the filed complaints are about screening programs in general, making the solution a bit more difficult to find. However, given these results, we can assume that something is impacting all Expedited Passenger Screening Programs at MCO...

Expedited Passenger Complaints by Sub-Category

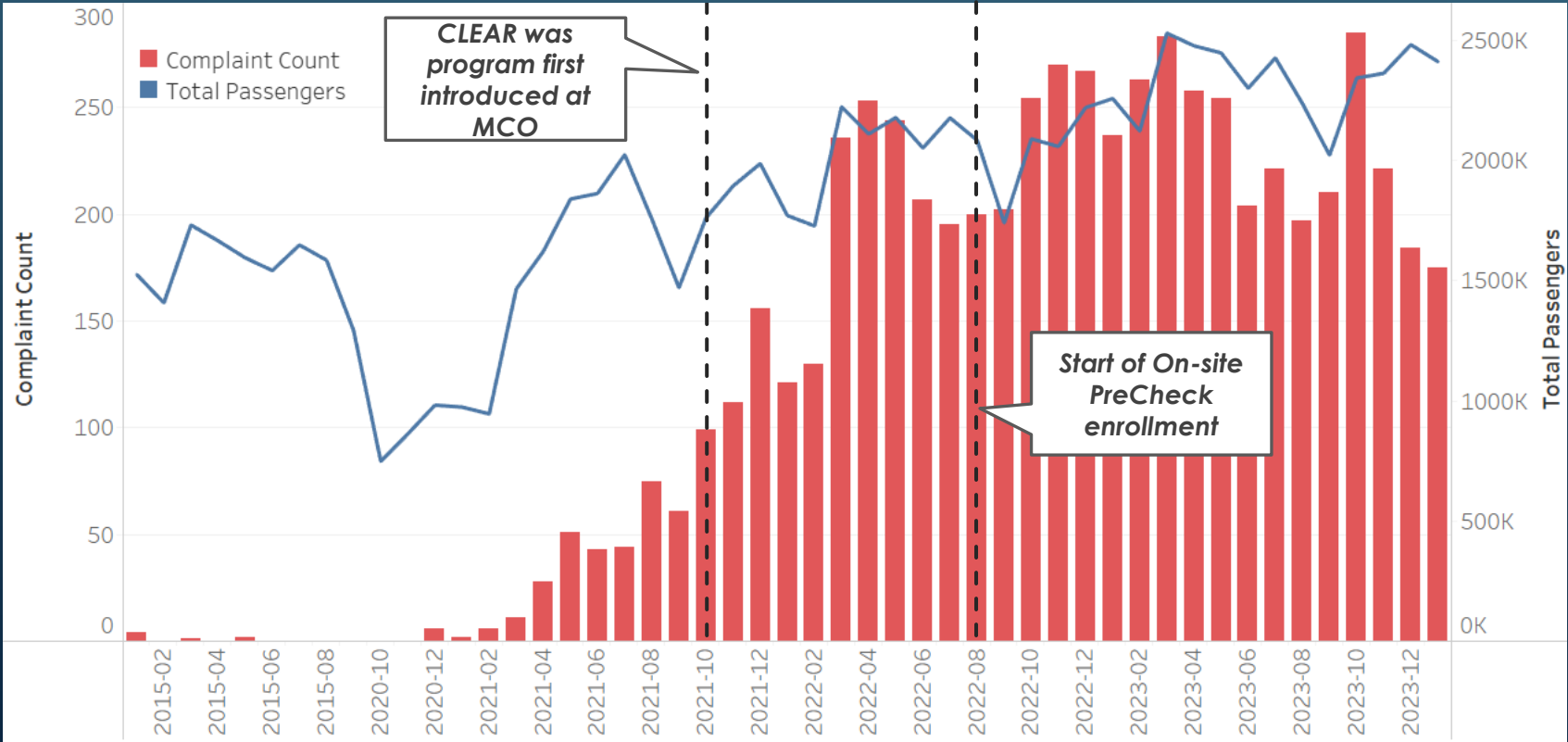


The Impact of CLEAR...



If we look more closely, we can see a sharp increase in the number of complaints after the implantation of the CLEAR program. While TSA PreCheck as been running since 2013. Even though CLEAR was intended to help travelers reserve a time slot for security screening, it is likely causing more harm than good. With further research on community threads such as Reddit, we found many complaints regarding how the CLEAR line was longer than standard or PreCheck lines, and lacking staff. Explaining the jump in complaints.

MCO Expedited Passenger Complaints by Month vs Total Passengers



Proposed Solution...



...**De-commission CLEAR**

CLEAR is a privately run operation that does not benefit our customers. It only but skips the initial ID verification, allowing some customers to skip the line to the front of security. Since ID verification is already a quick fast process, it only cuts down wait time by about 2 minuets on average. CLEAR is also only available to customers willing to pay the \$200 yearly fee. Which leads to increased frustration as non-members watch CLEAR customers cut them in line.

While MCO will be the first airport to de-commission CLEAR, we are not the first to discuss it. Law makers in CA are in the process of passing a law to ban all third-party airport checks due to security concerns.

MCO Expedited Passenger Complaints by Month vs Total Passengers

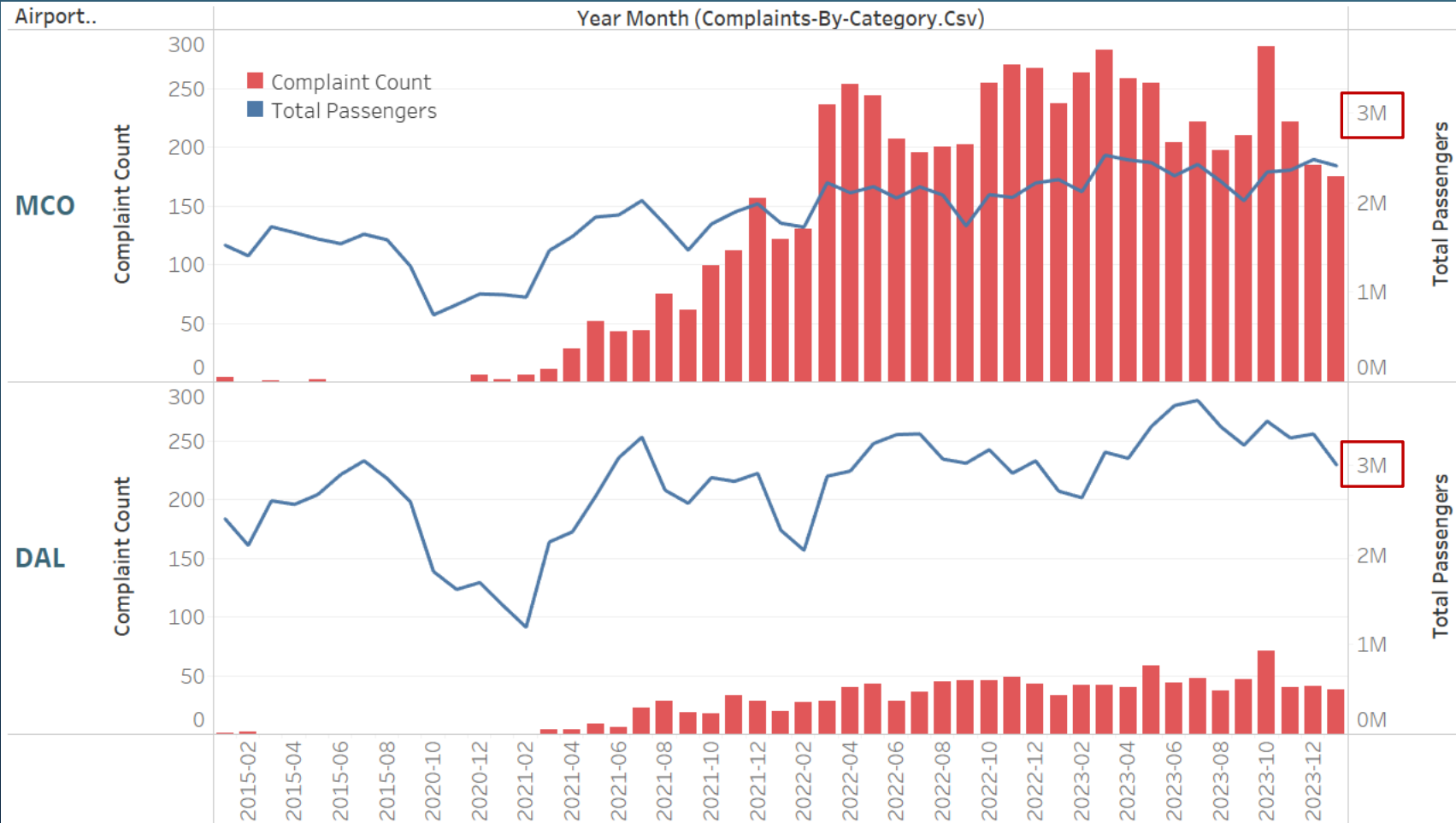
...Let's be the first to remove CLEAR And reduce customer complaints!

Why?



Some Airports such as DAL never implemented CLEAR. You can see below that even with the similar passage load, DAL managed to keep their Expedited Passenger Complaints much lower. Strengthening our hypothesis that CLEAR is to blame.

Airport Expedited Passenger Complaints by Month vs Total Passengers



Even with higher demand² than MCO, DAL kept their complaints low by not implementing CLEAR or other their similar parties.

²Bureau of Transportation Statistics. (n.d.).

THANK YOU

Amelia Farrell

DSC650-T301 Big Data

Bellevue University

REFERENCES

1. *Busiest airports in Florida* - Tampa Bay Business Journal. (2024, July 5). Tampa Bay Business Journal. <https://www.bizjournals.com/tampabay/subscriber-only/2024/07/05/busiest-airports-in-florida.html>
2. U.S. DEPARTMENT OF TRANSPORTATION. Bureau of Transportation Statistics. (n.d.). https://www.transtats.bts.gov/Data_Elements.aspx?Data=1
3. Administration, T. S. (2024, April 30). CLEAR becomes TSA's third official TSA PreCheck® enrollment provider. Prnewswire. https://www.prnewswire.com/news-releases/clear-becomes-tsas-third-official-tsa-precheck-enrollment-provider-302131510.html?utm_source=chatgpt.com